

ARYNA SABALENKA

A bad year for Sabalenka would be an excellent year for almost anyone else. After all, the Belarusian Basher started fast, winning Brisbane, making the Australian Open final, and capturing a rare 'Sunshine Double' (Indian Wells and Miami).

The rest of the season has ranged from disappointing to disastrous. At Roland Garros, befuddled by Diana Shnaider's tricky left-hander's game and swirling winds, Sabalenka led 6-3, 4-1, 30-love and then, astonishingly, lost the last 10 games and the quarterfinal, 3-6, 7-5, 6-0. In the Wimbledon fourth round, Naomi Osaka played almost flawless tennis to upset Sabalenka 6-2, 7-6 (2), snapping Sabalenka's streak of 21 straight tiebreak wins.

At the Cincinnati Open, the Sabalenka slump and funk continued. Throwing her racket in disgust after untimely errors, Sabalenka went down 7-6 (7), 6-4 to No. 35 Sara Bejlek, a 5ft 3in canny left-handed counterpuncher from Czechia who had never beaten a top-10 player before. The two-time defending champion won't retain her title, but she'll come close, losing yet another three-set heartbreaker.

Prediction: Finalist

No. 1



Before her career-changing 6-2, 5-7, 6-3 victory over compatriot Karolina Muchova in the Wimbledon final, Linda Noskova said she doesn't worry about rankings or the occasion. But Noskova let the occasion paralyse her in the second set when leading 6-2, 5-2 and holding five championship points. Muchova saved them all. The 21-year-old Noskova looked shaky again in the opening game of the deciding set but staved off three break points. Two games later, she escaped another break point and held for 3-0.

That's what champions do. Noskova had a relatively easy Wimbledon draw, facing only one top-10 opponent, No. 9 Muchova. But she checks all the boxes to win more Majors, particularly on the faster surfaces — grass and hard courts. Noskova boasts excellent power, disguise, and variety on her serve, and Mary Joe Fernandez rates her second serve, which averages 94 mph, "the best in the game." She volleys adeptly and has improved her defence. And crucially, she handles her nerves better than the other contenders.

Prediction: Champion

LINDA NOSKOVA

No. 8

